the cold war superpowers; India would be different because of its unique history and civilizational experience. Such beliefs are not just the ‘feel good’ avowals of leaders trying to rally their people but something believed by the lay Indian. Its deep-rootedness is visible in the presence of this belief even in the global Indian diaspora. Like other nations, including the US, who believe in national uniqueness and manifest destiny, Indians tend to abide by what they see as their principles and not give up on them as part of a compromise. This means firmly hanging on to non-alignment in a world that no longer has differing ideological blocs as well as seeking an independent position in the World Trade Organization that is often starkly opposite that of the Western countries.

India’s external relations reflect India’s view of self, which, in turn, is derived not just from ancient Hindu philosophers but has also been influenced by other developments through subsequent history. Medieval Muslim sultans added religious and cultural pluralism to Indian life. This legacy helped modern India shape its relations with Muslim countries to the west and north-west of India. Another heritage from the medieval era was the intense personalization of administration. The Mughals bequeathed to the British Raj a political culture focused on absolute personal power rather than on permanent institutions. The Raj left behind strong institutions with personality-driven administration to modern India.

The country was deeply influenced by almost two centuries of British rule, 110 years of it under the East India Company and another ninety directly under the British Crown. The British brought to India modern education, technology and institutions. They also made Indians more aware of their greater neighbourhood, stretching from the Middle East to South-East Asia and contributed to Indian understanding of contemporary global affairs. British Raj saw India as the jewel in its crown and the heart of its overseas empire. India provided a large supply of recruits for the colonial army; it was a low-cost producer as well as a captive market for British